Little Commanders

2–6 players · 30–45 minutes · ages 8+

Rulebook draft v0.3. Working title, art and numbers will change.

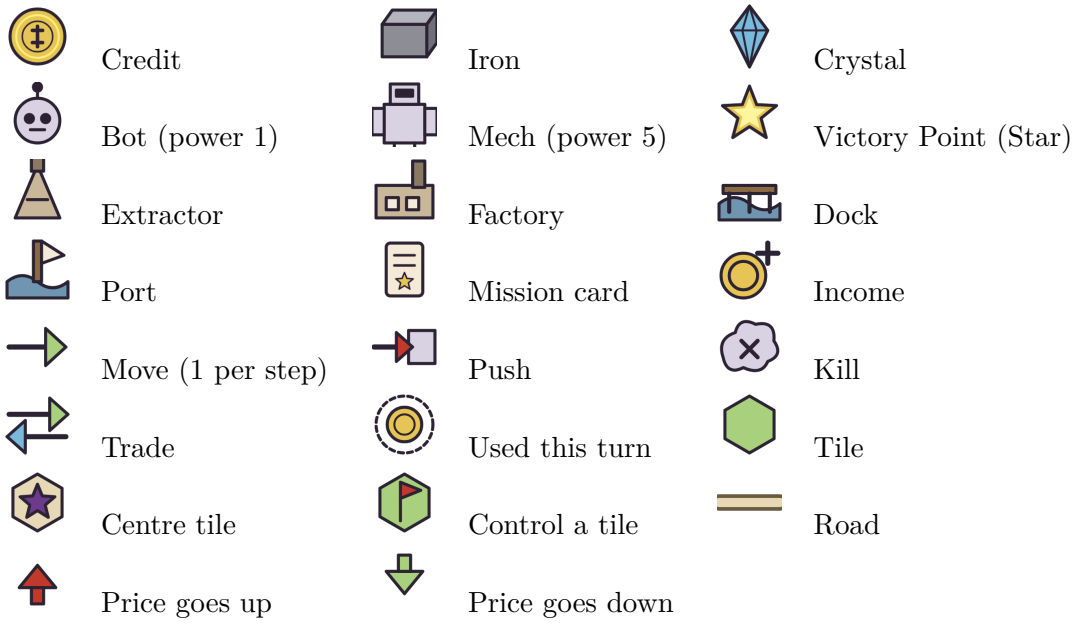
1 The Game in One Minute

You are a kid commander with cute little **Bots** and a few big **Mechs**. Spread across the hex floor, hold tiles, and complete **Missions** to earn **Victory Points**. The first commander to reach the target wins.

Two rules to remember. (1) You spend Credits to recruit, move and buy Missions. (2) Move onto an enemy tile with enough strength and its defenders must go. Everything else is printed on your board, the tiles and the cards.

2 Icons

The same pictures are used on tiles, cards, boards and in this book.



3 Components

- **Tiles:** 37 land tiles, 6 Home tiles, 12 Port tiles with two sides (front: all goods, back: two goods).
- **Boards:** 6 Commander boards (Basic side and Advanced side), 1 Market board (fixed prices on one side, price tracks on the other).
- **Per commander:** 20 Bots, 5 Mechs, 5 Extractors, 5 Factories, 1 Dock.
- **Tokens:** Iron, Crystal, Credit coins (1, 5, 10), price markers, VP markers.
- **Cards:** 40 Missions (20 of Level 1, 20 of Level 2).

4 Basic or Advanced

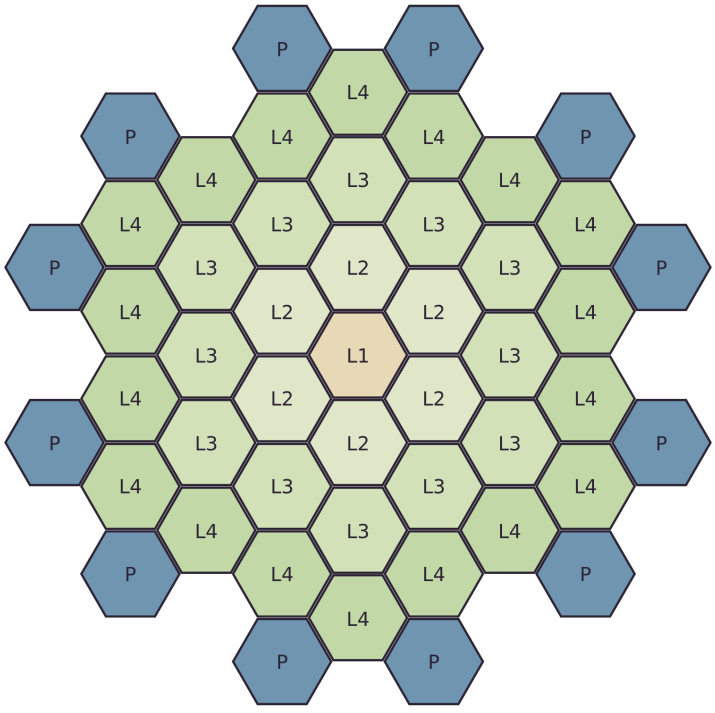
There are two ways to play. Both use the same board, pieces and Missions.

Basic	The market has fixed prices: Iron 3, Crystal 4, Bots 5, Mechs 10. A Port shows its front side and opens all four goods.
Advanced	The prices start the same but move 1 for every item bought or sold (Iron 1–6, Crystal 2–8, Bots 2–10, Mechs 3–12). A Port shows its back side and opens only two goods, drawn at random.

On BGA this is the *Rules* game option. Use the Basic side of your board for Basic, the Advanced side for Advanced.

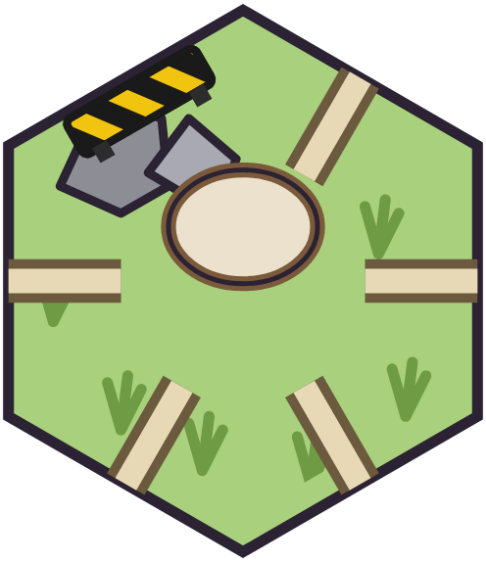
5 Setup

1. **Build the floor.** 2–3 players: 19 land tiles (centre and 2 rings). 4–6 players: 37 land tiles (centre and 3 rings). Shuffle the tiles of each ring and place them at random, then check that you can walk from the centre to every tile over roads that *both* touching tiles show (re-deal if not).
2. **Homes.** Space the Home tiles evenly on the outer ring. Each player takes the one in their colour with **3 Bots**, a Dock and **2 Iron**.
3. **Ports.** Place 2 Port tiles per player around the outside, each beside 2 land tiles (two players: 2 Ports on the free corners). Basic: front side up. Advanced: back sides, drawn at random.
4. **Missions.** Reveal 5 Missions from a deck of Level 1 cards with Level 2 cards below.
5. **Market.** Basic: the fixed prices are printed on the board. Advanced: put each price marker on its START square (Iron 3, Crystal 4, Bots 5, Mechs 10).



Four to six players: 37 land tiles and 12 Ports (shown schematically; L = land level, P = port).

6 Reading a Tile



Everything you need is printed on the tile itself.

- **Ground:** green Iron mine, blue Crystal deposit, grey empty tile, or a green tile with both resources.
- **Sockets:** 0, 1 or 2 round building areas where you may build.
- **Roads:** a road runs to every edge except one: that edge is blocked by hazard stripes. Pieces only travel where *both* tiles are open.
- **Ports:** the front shows all four goods, the back shows the two goods that Port opens.

The centre and the Home tiles have all six roads open; every other tile has exactly one blocked edge. The centre can be crossed but not stopped on. Letters and numbers around the board name every tile; the game log uses the same names.

7 Your Turn

At the start of your turn gain **3 Credits plus 1 for every land tile you control** and take the coins off your buildings. Then do any of the following, in any order. End your turn when you are done. Your attacks are decided then.

Control

You **control** a tile while at least one of your pieces stands on it. Buildings and tokens on a tile belong to whoever controls it. Bots cannot be assigned to anything; they hold tiles and attack.

Build and Make

Spend iron that is standing on the tile on a free socket there. Build your first Extractor with your starting Iron.

Extractor	Once per turn, pay 1 Credit: take 1 token of the tile's resource.	1
Factory	Once per turn, pay 1 Credit: 1 becomes 2 , or 1 + 1 becomes 1 .	2

When a building works, put a coin on it. Take the coins back at the start of your turn. You may sell a building: it returns to your board and you get its cost minus 1 Iron on the tile. Resource tokens belong to whoever holds the tile; carry them with your pieces (they pay like pieces when they move).

Move

Move any pieces together from a tile you control: **1 Credit per step for the whole group**, however many pieces go. Pieces follow open roads and cannot pass through enemy pieces. Iron and crystal only travel with a Bot (one at the start and one at the destination).

Trade

Trade at your Dock or at a Port next to a tile you control. There is no fee and no limit: buy or sell any amount, as often as you like, all at the current price.

- **Dock:** Iron and Bots. **Port:** all four goods (front side) or the two printed on its back.
- **Basic:** the price never changes.
- **Advanced:** after the whole trade the price moves 1 for every item: when you buy, when you sell. You cannot buy and sell the same good in one turn. Ranges: Iron 1–6, Crystal 2–8, Bots 2–10, Mechs 3–12.

Missions

Pay **5 Credits** to buy a face-up Mission, plus 1 for every Mission you have bought. You may buy one per turn. If you meet it *at that moment*, you score its (1 for Level 1 cards, 2 for Level 2 cards). If not, the Credits are lost. A completed card is replaced from the deck.



Combat

Move onto an enemy tile to attack it. Attackers walk in; the attack is decided when you end your turn.

- Bot power 1. Mech power 5. Add up each side's power.
- **Push:** attackers have at least 2× the defenders' power. The defenders retreat; the defending player chooses where each piece goes.
- **Kill:** at least 3×. The defenders are removed.
- Not enough? The attack **fails** and the attackers return to where they came from.

Winning

Be first to **5** Victory Points. Points come only from Missions.

8 Factions

Each commander has a colour and a different silhouette, so the game also works without colour vision. Faction powers are an optional extra still being designed.

9 Your Board

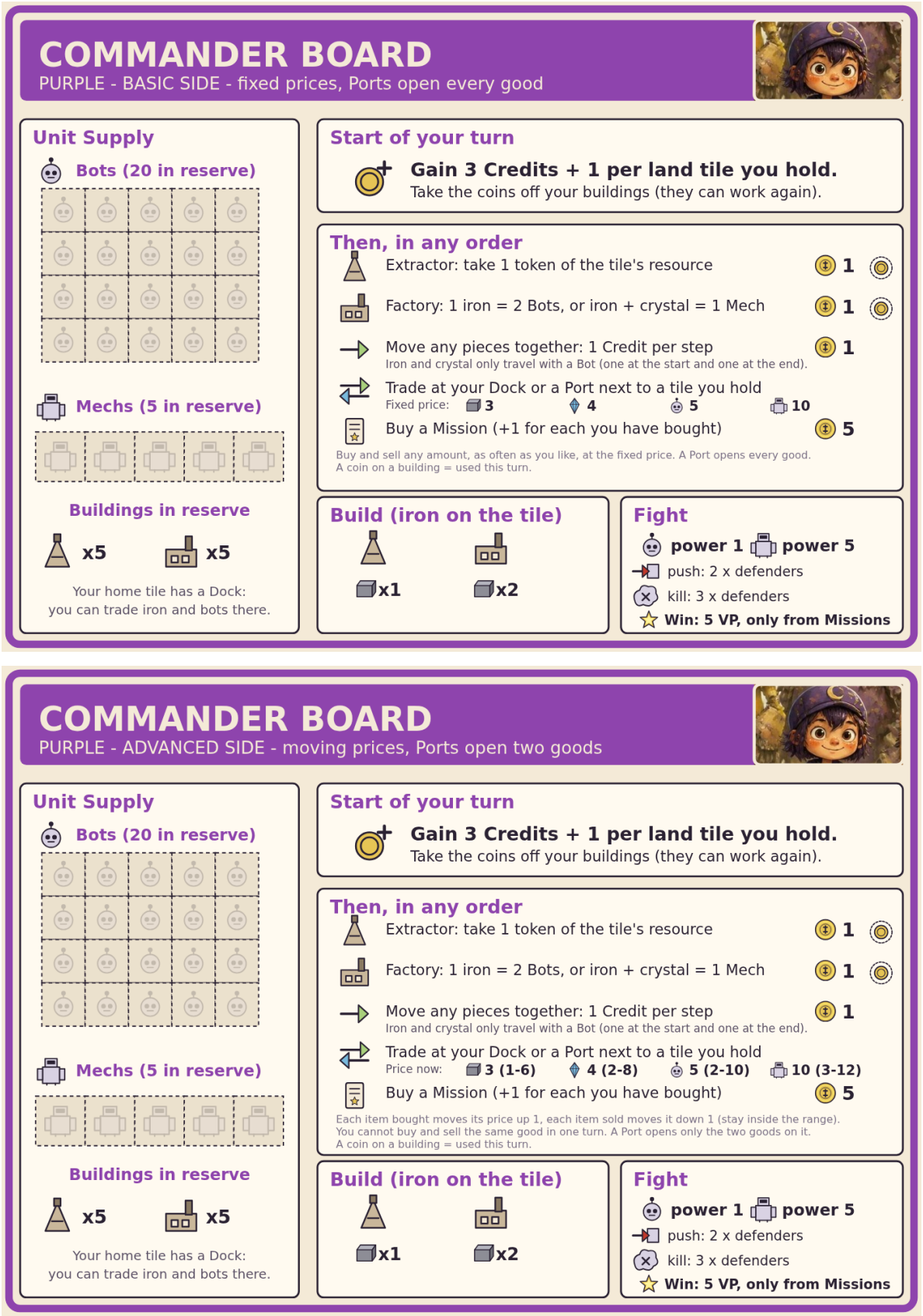


Figure 1: Basic side (front) and Advanced side (back).

10 Draft Notes

- Income is 3 Credits plus 1 per land tile; movement is 1 Credit per step for the whole group.
- The market still prices a whole trade at today's price before moving, so big buy-and-sell loops between a Dock and a Port can print Credits. Needs per-item price steps or fixed port prices.